Therapist guide | Core 02

From an everyday situation to shared understanding

Core 02 guide: Distinguish event, meaning, feeling, body sensations, action and outcome through one example.

Purpose of this unit

Help the client identify parts of the experience in their own words and explore possible links. Useful work does not require identifying every part, agreeing on one explanation or changing the feeling.

Connecting with the previous unit

Open with SES-S01 and return to the goal and step chosen in Core 1. Ask what happened and what the client learned, including barriers or noncompletion. Choose an event connected to the goal or another moment the client wants to understand.

Suggested way of working

1. Choose a specific recent situation with a manageable emotional load. It may also be pleasant or neutral.

2. First ask what could be seen or heard, then what it meant to the client.

3. Make room for feelings, body sensations and responses, and explore immediate and later events.

4. Reflect the account and check its fit. Offer a link as a hypothesis, not a proven fact.

5. Decide together what to practice and on what scale; end with SES-S02, feedback and a check of understanding.

Using the existing sheet

Use the age-appropriate CORE-02-W. Version 0.2 describes situation, thought, feeling, response and effect, alongside conditions and support. Exploring alternative interpretations is reserved for Core 4 as needed. Questions may be left blank; completing the sheet is optional.

Mindful Path

Therapist guide | Core 02

Distinguishing without rushing to correct

The following fictional examples illustrate distinctions within an account, rather than suggesting a correct interpretation of a real situation.

Group	A brief example to explore in conversation
Children	Situation: A game started before I arrived. Thought: There is no place for me. Feeling and body: Sadness and heaviness. Response: I stayed aside. Outcome: I did not ask to join. Explore what is actually known and what the child wants.
Adolescents	Situation: A message was sent, with no reply by evening. Interpretation: They are angry with me. Feeling: Worry. Response: I checked my phone again. Explore the effect of checking and what remains unknown.
Adults	Situation: A colleague asked to talk after a meeting. Interpretation: I made a mistake. Feeling and body: Apprehension and tension. Response: I postponed the conversation. Explore what happened and its meaning for the person.
Older adults	Situation: An important activity was canceled. Thought: I will have nothing to do today. Feeling: Disappointment. Response: I stayed home. Explore circumstances, needs and options without assuming what fits.

Mindful Path

Useful distinctions

A thought may be a sentence or image; a feeling may be sadness, fear or anger; a body sensation may be tension or warmth. Saying I feel unwanted includes a meaning to explore gently alongside the feeling. Do not turn the distinction into a quiz.

Experience is not a fixed chain

Body, feeling, thought and behavior can influence each other. A body sensation or action may be noticed before a thought. External context and reality matter; do not attribute every difficulty to the client's interpretation.

Response and outcome

Explore what the action allowed and its consequences in that context. A protective or relieving response may be helpful. Do not classify every avoidance as a problem or dismiss actual harm through a positive interpretation.

Therapist guide | Core 02

Age adaptations and difficult situations

These instructions are a basis for adapting with the client. Ability, preferences and context take precedence over an age label.

Group	A possible way to guide the work
Children, approximately ages 6 to 11	One concrete moment, one short question at a time and oral completion if comfortable. The therapist can write and check their understanding. A parent helps only in the agreed role, without replacing the child's account.
Adolescents, approximately ages 12 to 17	Allow choice of event and recording method. Explain limits on privacy and sharing; identifying details may be omitted. Explore personal meaning without drawing the adolescent into an argument.
Adults	Choose a context connected to the person's life goal, including actual circumstances and demands. A few words may be enough, with fuller discussion aloud.
Older adults	Preserve adult language and choice. Offer a suitable pace, explanation, spoken completion or accessibility adaptation without assuming reduced ability.

When a thought cannot be recalled

Gently ask what went through the person's mind or what the moment meant. Write not remembered or leave it blank. Label any suggested hypothesis as a later possibility, not a memory. Start with known feelings, body sensations or actions if helpful.

When overload occurs or the sheet feels judgmental

Limit the work to one section, change the recording method or postpone it. Professional assessment and adapting to the situation take priority over completion. There is no need to revisit an especially difficult event for this exercise.

When perspectives differ

The therapist reflects uncertainty and checks what fits the client's account. A parent's or support person's information remains an additional source. Disagreeing about an interpretation is not the client's failure.

Mindful Path

Therapist guide | Core 02

Practice, review and closing the unit

CORE-02-P sheets complement the worksheet. Plan together and bring learning back to the next session's conversation.

Before practice

Choose an everyday moment, recording method and feasible scope. Check that the client can explain their choice in their own words. Do not direct them to create an overwhelming or risky situation just to have something to write. Oral completion next session is a valid option.

At the next meeting

Explore what happened, what helped and remaining questions. If the sheet was not completed, check burden, clarity, privacy and timing, and adapt the task. Completion itself and changes in emotional intensity are not the sole measures of learning.

What supports moving forward

The client can describe at least part of one event and make a useful distinction, such as between what happened and their thoughts about it. This supports judgment; it is not a pass test. Repeat or move on according to shared assessment. Core 3 explores thoughts and recurring patterns.

Content status and sources

The wording and examples were written independently for this kit. Each age adaptation still needs professional and rights review before distribution. The sources below provide general background; they neither approve this kit nor license external forms.

Beck Institute: Understanding CBT
General background on the cognitive model and person-centered work.
https://beckinstitute.org/about/understanding-cbt/

Beck Institute Cares: What Are CBT Sessions Like?
Background on collaboration, agenda, action planning and feedback.
https://cares.beckinstitute.org/about-cbt/what-are-sessions-like/

Reference date: 03.11.2026. Guide and drafts only; no professional review has been completed.

Reviewer's name, role, date and versions reviewed:

Mindful Path